the resistance from Air India was stiff, the government asked us if there was any other airline willing to bring the consignment.

Dunayev once again proved his friendship with India by offering the services of Russian Ural Airlines, a private airline. We finalised the schedule for export. Four flights of Ural Airlines would carry the consignment to India. One or two of the four flights, as per the schedule, were to have a stopover at Karachi (during my interrogation in the ISRO spy case later that year, the Intelligence Bureau, having collected some bits and pieces of this transshipment, had tried to link the Karachi stopover to an imaginary Pakistani connection).

The first flight (URL 224) from Moscow landed in Trivandrum on 23 January 1994 after a stopover in Karachi. The second flight (URL 9001) landed on 11 March 1994. The third (URL 3791) via Sharjah reached Trivandrum on 17 July 1994. The fourth and last flight carrying the cryogenic engine material was to come in December.

Before that, on 30 November 1994, the Kerala police arrested me in the fabricated ISRO spy case.

The foreign conspirators' political masters can pat themselves on the back for this achievement, for the case came at the most opportune time for them as India was at the cusp of a cryogenic leap.

Here is more from Harvey's book *Russia in Space: The Failed Frontier?*:

'The plot thickened when at the same time, in October (sic) 1994, two scientists at the Indian Liquid Propulsion Systems Centre, S Nambi Narayanan and P Sasikumaran, were arrested for 'spying for foreign countries'. Eventually the Central Bureau of Investigation admitted that the charges against S Nambi Narayanan and P Sasikumaran were false and baseless and they were freed. Later, the United States was accused of setting them up as part of a dirty tricks campaign against the sale of the KVD-1.'

So why did the Americans want to scuttle the Indian space programme? For the uninitiated, here is what J Rajasekharan Nair, author of the book *Spies*